

Lab 06 Reflection

At first, my goal for this basemap was to create a cartoon-style map that felt playful and clearly different from standard navigation maps. After a few attempts, I realized the cartoon approach wasn't turning out the way I envisioned, especially when viewing the map at different zoom levels. Instead of forcing a style that didn't feel coherent, I shifted my design direction toward something more minimalistic and viewer-friendly: a clean, readable basemap that still felt distinct from a traditional Apple or Google map. I kept the overall design simple, but added my own "spin" through customized colors, subtle contrast choices, and layer styling so the map still felt personal and intentionally designed.

The biggest cartographic challenge was designing for multiple scales. The main issue was making sure the font and outlines stayed visually balanced as new layers appeared during zooming. When zoomed out, I wanted the map to show only the most important information, so it wouldn't feel cluttered across a larger area of Colorado. As the user zooms in, the map gradually reveals more detail, including smaller roads and buildings, so the map becomes more useful for actually locating the places in my dataset. Getting this "progressive detail" right took the most trial and error, because even small changes to label size, casing thickness, or feature visibility can make the map feel either too empty or too busy depending on the zoom level.

On the technical side, I didn't run into major coding issues when creating the interactive map. Since we worked through the process in class, I already understood the general workflow. I used AI as a support tool to help assemble the Python script structure, connect to the Mapbox Geocoding API, and format the Folium popups with images and descriptions. Overall, the combination of class guidance and AI assistance made the coding portion smooth, and I was able to focus more on clean design, correct symbolization by category, and making sure the basemap and the data worked together as a complete final product.